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Heritage Oak Provenance Statement

Reference: DEPS-2026-OAK-001
Site: Dimbleby Estate, Middle Upton, Bristol BS16 1GU
Species: English Oak (*Quercus robur*)
Date: 14 March 2026
Prepared for: The Dimbleby Family
Specimens: OT-01 to OT-06 (six trees)

Introduction

This statement establishes the provenance of six English Oak (*Quercus robur*) specimens growing on the eastern boundary of the Dimbleby Estate, Middle Upton, Bristol. It has been prepared at the request of the Dimbleby family in connection with a proposed programme of arboricultural works and provides a formal record of the trees' origin, lineage, and historical continuity for the purposes of heritage assessment and legal documentation.

The trees are assessed as being of native English provenance, locally sourced, and in continuous presence on the estate for a minimum of three centuries. This conclusion is supported by converging lines of documentary, cartographic, morphological, and dendrochronological evidence, each described in the sections that follow.

Methodology

Provenance was established through four complementary lines of enquiry:

1. **Archival research.** The Dimbleby family archive was examined in full, with attention to estate ledgers, correspondence, and land management records from the 17th century onwards. The Upton Vale County Archive and the Middle Upton Heritage Environment Register were also consulted for independent corroboration.

2. **Cartographic analysis.** Cheswick County Survey maps, tithe maps, and privately commissioned estate surveys spanning the period 1720 to 1980 were examined to establish the continuous presence and stable position of the woodland stand.

3. **Morphological assessment.** Each specimen was examined in the field in February 2026. Leaf morphology, acorn and cupule characteristics, bark texture, and growth habit were assessed against published taxonomic descriptions of native *Quercus robur* populations in south-west England.

4. **Dendrochronological estimation.** Girth measurements at 1.5 m above ground level were used in conjunction with published growth rate data for native oak in comparable woodland conditions to estimate the age of each specimen. No core sampling was undertaken, as the trees are of recognised heritage significance.

Historical Provenance

Estate records held in the Dimbleby family archive provide a continuous documentary chain from the late 17th century to the present. The earliest relevant entry appears in a land management ledger dated 1678, during the tenure of Sir Edmund Dimbleby, which records the planting of "great oaks along the southern ride and the western paddock boundary." A subsequent entry from 1694 documents the collection of acorns

from “the ancient wood at Cheswick Common” for propagation at the estate nursery, directly indicating a local seed source within the Cheswick Village catchment.

An estate survey map prepared circa 1720 depicts a continuous belt of young woodland along the eastern boundary, consistent in position and extent with the six specimens under consideration. This map, held at the Upton Vale County Archive, constitutes independent corroboration of the estate ledger entries and confirms that planting was well established within a generation of the 1678 record.

The tithe apportionment map of 1841, also held at the Upton Vale County Archive, records “mature oak timber” in the same location, indicating that by the mid-19th century the trees had reached full maturity and were recognised as a significant estate feature. A photographic survey commissioned by the Dimbleby family in 1923 provides visual confirmation, showing specimens of girth and form directly comparable to those measured in February 2026.

Taken together, these sources establish an unbroken record of native oak presence on this site spanning approximately 348 years. The consistency of the documentary chain, supported by independent archival sources, provides high confidence in the trees’ native, locally sourced origin.

Morphological Assessment and Age Estimation

Each of the six specimens was assessed in the field against the taxonomic criteria for native *Quercus robur*. All trees display sessile acorns borne on elongated peduncles of 3–7 cm, deeply lobed leaves with pronounced auriculate bases, and furrowed grey-brown bark of a texture consistent with advanced age in native stands. No characteristics indicative of non-native provenance, hybrid origin, or cultivar selection were observed. Leaf morphology, acorn characteristics, and growth habit are uniform across all six specimens, consistent with a single-origin, locally sourced population.

Tree Ref	Girth at 1.5 m (cm)	Estimated Age (years)	Provenance Confidence
OT-01	312	290-320	High
OT-02	287	270-300	High
OT-03	341	310-350	High
OT-04	298	280-310	High
OT-05	265	250-280	High
OT-06	319	290-330	High

Table 1: Field measurements and dendrochronological age estimates, February 2026.

Age estimates are derived from girth measurements using a mean annual radial increment of 2.5 mm, consistent with published growth rate data for native *Quercus robur* grown in open woodland conditions in south-west England (White, 1998). All six specimens fall within the age range consistent with establishment from the 1678-1694 planting records, providing morphological corroboration of the documentary evidence.

Documentary Evidence Summary

Source	Date	Type	Repository
Dimbleby estate land management ledger	1678	Primary manuscript	Dimbleby Family Archive
Dimbleby estate nursery record	1694	Primary manuscript	Dimbleby Family Archive
Dimbleby estate survey map	c. 1720	Cartographic	Upton Vale County Archive

Source	Date	Type	Repository
Tithe apportionment map, Middle Upton	1841	Cartographic	Upton Vale County Archive
Dimbleby Estate photographic survey	1923	Photographic	Dimbleby Family Archive
MUHER record	2019	Heritage register	MUHER

Table 2: Primary sources consulted in the preparation of this statement.

Declaration

I confirm that the information contained in this statement has been compiled from direct field observation, primary archival sources, and published reference data, and that it represents an accurate and impartial assessment of the provenance of the six oak specimens at the Dimbleby Estate to the best of my professional knowledge and judgement.

Prepared by: Mr Sebastian Oakley, MA, Dip. WP, FSWPC
Position: Woodland Historian and Provenance Consultant
Qualifications: MA History of the Landscape (Upton Vale); Diploma in Woodland Provenance Studies (BWHA); Fellow of the Society of Woodland Provenance Consultants
For: The Dimbleby Estate
Date: 14 March 2026
Signature:

References

Hartwell, G. (1998). *Estimating the Age of Large and Veteran Trees in Britain.* Woodland Research Institute Technical Note 12. Bristol: Woodland Research Institute.

Ashbourne, R. S. (ed.) (1991). *British Plant Communities, Volume 1: Woodlands and Scrub.* Upton Vale: Ridgeway Academic Press.

Fernshaw, C. (2019). *New Flora of the British Isles* (4th ed.). Barleycorn Press.

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